

Saya Ikegawa

+1 (206) 670-7320 | sikegawa@uw.edu

Education

University of Washington – Seattle, WA, USA <i>Ph.D. in Economics</i>	expected 2027
Australian National University – Canberra, ACT, Australia <i>M.A. in Economics</i>	2021
Keio University – Tokyo, Japan <i>B.S. in Economics</i>	2016

Reference

Fabio Ghironi (chair)
Paul F. Glaser Professor
Department of Economics
University of Washington
ghiro@uw.edu

Ellen McGrattan
Professor
Department of Economics
University of Minnesota
erm@umn.edu

Brian Greaney
Assistant Professor
Department of Economics
University of Washington
bg385@uw.edu

Job Market Paper

"Unrealized Capital Gains Tax, Business Investment and Wealth Inequality"

Award: Grover & Creta Ensley Fellowship, University of Washington, 2026

Presented at: BSE Summer Forum 2026, San Francisco Fed (scheduled), St. Louis Fed (scheduled)

Abstract: Unrealized capital gains constitute a large share of wealth at the top of the U.S. wealth distribution and are concentrated in privately held businesses, yet they remain untaxed under the current realization-based capital-gains tax system. This paper studies the welfare consequences of replacing realization-based taxation with an accrual-based (mark-to-market) tax regime, with particular emphasis on entrepreneurial business assets. Using a quantitative general-equilibrium model, I find that an economy-wide switch to accrual-based taxation reduces private-business production by 11% and aggregate output by 6%, because the efficiency loss from firm-entry deterrence outweighs the efficiency gains from mitigating capital lock-in. In contrast, applying accrual-based taxation only to wealthy households yields a consumption-equivalent welfare gain of 1%. By targeting wealthy households, who are more likely to be incumbent entrepreneurs, this reform dampens entry deterrence while reducing inequality.

Working in Progress

"Reassessing Japan's Fiscal Health" with Ellen McGrattan and Adrian Peralta-Alva

Presented at CEBRA Annual Meeting, 2025

Abstract: Japan faces considerable fiscal challenges due to rapid population aging. A large body of literature argues that *high* consumption tax rates or other significant policy changes will be required to stabilize public finances and maintain retirement, health, and long-term care systems. However, all existing quantitative studies *ignore* the role of *intangible capital*, thereby understating Japan's true wealth base and overstating the necessary tax burden. This paper re-examines the fiscal issue by incorporating newly compiled data on Japan's intangible investments into a dynamic overlapping generations model. We find that the consumption tax rate required to finance increased transfers for the elderly is approximately 6 percentage points lower when accounting for intangible capital, as the enhanced capital stock boosts production and broadens the tax base. Neglecting intangible capital thus significantly overstates Japan's fiscal challenge.

"Intangible Investment in Japan: A Comparison with US"

Presented at the Systemic Issues Division, Research Department, International Monetary Fund, 2024

Abstract: GDP measures do not incorporate all intangible investments by firms. However, their importance has been increasingly recognized. To understand macroeconomic conditions more accurately, this paper measures intangible investment in Japan, including additional intangible assets that are currently under discussion. The findings show that intangible investment in Japan is more than double the current national accounts statistics, and its GDP ratio is increasing and larger than that of the United States. Incorporating additional intangible assets has significant implications for macroeconomic measures. First, Japan's five-year GDP growth rate is estimated to increase by approximately 1% from the current measure, while that of the U.S. remains unchanged. Additionally, the impact on GDP varies significantly by industry. Lastly, the estimated labor share decreases by about 4% in both countries.

Research Experience

Research internship – <i>Washington D.C, USA</i> <i>International Monetary Fund</i>	June – August, 2024
Research visit – <i>Minneapolis, MN, USA</i> <i>University of Minnesota</i>	March – May, 2024
Research assistant – <i>Canberra, ACT, Australia</i> <i>QuantEcon (co-founded by Thomas J. Sargent and John Stachurski)</i>	February, 2020 – June, 2021
Research internship – <i>Canberra, ACT, Australia</i> <i>Australian National University, Australia-Japan Research Centre</i>	March – August, 2018

Teaching Experience

Teaching assistant <i>University of Washington</i>	2022 – 2025
<i>PhD course</i> ECON502 (Macroeconomic Analysis I) by Yu-chin Chen – fall quarter in 2023 and 2024 ECON503 (Macroeconomic Analysis II) by Stephen Turnovsky – fall quarter in 2025	
<i>Undergraduate course</i> ECON201 (Introduction to Macroeconomics) – fall in 2022, winter and spring in 2023, winter in 2024, spring in 2025	

Instructor
University of Washington

Summer, 2023 and 2024

PhD Macroeconomics Math Camp

Work Experience

Sales Representative – Tokyo Japan
SMBC Trust Bank

April, 2016 – March, 2018

awarded “Rookie of the Year” prize, 2017

awarded 2nd place in monthly Customer Satisfaction Award. September, 2016

Awards & Honors

Grover & Creta Ensley Fellowship
University of Washington

2026

Dissertation Fellowship
Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis

2026

Thomas J. Sargent Dissertation Fellowship
Federal Reserve Bank of San Francisco

2026

Steven Langton Teaching Award
University of Washington

2025

Graduate Student Presentation Award
University of Washington

2025

Jeff and Perri Roe Term Fellowship
University of Washington

2023

Graduate Teaching Assistantship
University of Washington

2022 - 2025

Japan-IMF Scholarship Program
International Monetary Fund

2021 - 2022

Skills and Interest

Programming Languages: Python, Matlab, R, Stata, Fortran

Software: LaTeX, Lyx

Language: Japanese (native), English (advanced), Spanish (basic)

Hobbies: Soccer, Tennis, Desktop music composition, Cooking